

The Impact of Media Supply on Bureaucratic Information Collection

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Abstract

How do bureaucracies seek information? Bureaucrats rely on news media to navigate a complex information environment and make strategic decisions, yet the volume of news is overwhelming. Agencies, therefore, contract private firms to distill news into daily “clipbooks” of relevant stories. I analyze these clipbooks across U.S. executive agencies and find a systematic skew. Conservative news sources appear more often in briefings for conservative agencies like Immigration and Customs Enforcement. The skew does not appear to arise from biased news selection; instead, it mirrors the news supply. Conservative outlets generally produce less content about liberal agencies, and vice versa. Because of this supply asymmetry, liberal agencies receive very little news from conservative sources. While the pattern is generally stable across administrations, there is some evidence of biased selection during Trump’s second term, representing a clear departure from prior periods. I close by discussing how these disparities in coverage may affect agency decision making and representation.

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1. Introduction

The news media produces a vast amount of politically relevant information every day, far more than any individual could possibly consume. As a result, news exposure depends on how information is collected and filtered. For political elites, the stakes of news collection are particularly high. Because timely political information can shape decisions, federal agencies invest heavily in monitoring, curating, and disseminating news. Faced with limited time and resources, bureaucracies must strategically prioritize the most important and relevant news.

This paper examines news collection within U.S. federal agencies, revealing that agencies have institutionalized systems for producing daily news compilations—typically called daily news briefings, summaries, or “clipbooks.” The content of these briefings reflects supply of news as well as the priorities of agencies and those individuals tasked with overseeing news collection. By comparing news selection across agencies and presidential administrations, I reveal how the very system designed to ensure that officials are well-informed can itself filter, distort, or politicize information. These processes matter: the information that reaches federal decisionmakers determines which actors, issues, and narratives are most visible and shapes beliefs about the larger strategic environment.

Although scholars have shown that media can shape the behavior of elected officials (Green-Pedersen & Stubager, 2010; Karpowitz, 2009; Sevenans, 2017a; Vliegenthart, Walgrave, Wouters, et al., 2016; Vliegenthart, Walgrave, Baumgartner, et al., 2016), we still know surprisingly little about their actual news exposure,¹ and even less about how unelected bureaucrats consume news media. This paper addresses that gap by examining why federal agencies collect news, revealing how agency news exposure is shaped by the supply of relevant news and how agency politicization affects demand for partisan news content. Beyond the study of news media, this paper also speaks more generally to information collection processes within bureaucracies.

To investigate agency news collection, I assemble an original dataset of more than 2,000

¹Although see Karpowitz (2009), Willis (2013), and Severin-Nielsen et al. (2025).

daily news briefings from four executive agencies—the Department of Interior (DOI), Department of Veterans Affairs (VA), US Citizenship and Immigration Service (USCIS), and Department of Homeland Security (DHS)—along with government manuals, contracts, and internal emails obtained through Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) requests and public archives.

I combine insights from existing theory with evidence from internal government records to show that agency media monitoring serves several overlapping purposes. News provides information essential for public communications, supports policymaking, and allows agencies to track the actions of other political actors. Satisfying all constituencies within an agency generally incentives broad, comprehensive news collection. Yet the content of a news briefing is ultimately constrained by the supply of relevant news and subject to manipulation by employees involved in news collection. To evaluate how individual and agency incentives shape news collection, I evaluate the volume of partisan news coverage in daily news briefings from different agencies and presidential administrations.

I begin by examining whether agencies preferentially select news sources that align with their own ideological tendencies. While agency ideology is correlated with the partisan composition of the briefings, this association reflects asymmetries in the supply of news rather than biased selection. Right-leaning outlets produce disproportionately fewer stories about liberal agencies, and left-leaning outlets generate fewer stories about conservative agencies. By matching articles in the briefings to the broader news supply, I show that articles from right- and left-leaning news sources are equally likely to be included in the news briefings. These findings are consistent with agency incentives to pursue comprehensive monitoring. At the same time, the supply-side disparity raises new concerns, especially because it generalizes to a larger set of agencies. Even when selection is unbiased, the final product can still provide a partial and incomplete picture of public opinion and the larger political environment.

I then consider whether the partisan affiliation of agency leadership affects news selection by examining whether news briefings change after a new President takes office. In line

with agency incentives for comprehensive information-seeking, the distribution of partisan news in Interior Department briefings was largely stable after Donald Trump took office in 2017. However, reflecting the recent politicization of government news consumption, the composition of briefings began to change after Trump returned to office in 2025. After March 2025, the Homeland Security briefings contain unusually high levels of conservative news, especially in the most visible and influential portions.

In summary, while agency news collection has always been shaped by the interaction between media monitoring tools and the media supply, the composition of news in the briefings is usually consistent with the needs of the agency as a whole. Variation in partisan content can be explained by the supply of partisan news rather than preferential selection of ideologically-aligned news outlets. However, in a highly partisan climate where news has been politicized, agency leadership may prioritize collecting information from likeminded sources.

2. Background

News contains valuable information that agencies use to inform their communications efforts, policy implementation, and other strategic decisions. However, bureaucrats have limited time to search for and consume information (Baumgartner & Jones, 2015). This problem has been intensified by the rise of the internet and fragmentation of news (Bawden & Robinson, 2009). To solve this tradeoff, US agencies and other elite actors optimize information collection by creating daily news briefings. The content of these briefings varies depending on an agency's motives for media monitoring and the underlying supply of news.

2.1. What are daily news briefings?

Like many political elites, federal agencies collect and distribute news.² The particular tools used for media monitoring vary depending on exact needs and resources of the user, but all of them involve searching a range of sources for news about specific topics of interest (Sullivan, 2012).

To better understand the purpose of agency daily news summaries, I submitted Freedom of Information Act Requests (FOIAs) for internal emails, documents, and contracts related to custom daily media monitoring reports. I also reviewed contracts for media monitoring posted on USAspending.gov, examined solicitations for contracts on sam.gov, and searched through online archives where journalists and organizations post FOIA documents. Collectively, these documents reveal how the US government expends considerable resources on news collection and how news is circulated within government agencies.³

Historically, news clipping services, government employees, and interns were tasked with identifying relevant news clips (Sullivan, 2012). Sometimes, these clips were combined into daily ‘clipbooks.’ Other times, a written ‘summary’ or ‘briefing’ of the day’s coverage was produced. The clipbooks and briefings were usually ordered by topic, with the most important stories appearing first (Sullivan, 2012).

Today, most large agencies employ third party vendors to compile an electronic daily news briefing or clipbook that is emailed every morning to a large number of staff.⁴ While government employees consume news outside of clipbooks and briefings,⁵ these documents

²While federal bureaucracies have more resources than many other elites, legislators and interest groups engage in similar topic-based media monitoring (National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, 2020; Willis, 2013).

³In addition to sam.gov and USAspending.gov, which are public databases maintained by the government, I also reviewed documents posted on Document Cloud and produced through Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) requests (CPSC 25-F-00254, DEA 25-00431-F, DOL 2025-F-06163, EOIR 2019-26810, EPA 2025-EPA-05231, EPA 2025-EPA-01013, FBI No.1657904, JMD FOIA 136110, NRC FOIA-2025-000404, OCC 2025-00151-F, SBA 2025-001843, SS No.20250423). For a detailed list of contracts and documents, see the Supplementary online appendix.

⁴Using USAspending.gov, I identified 26 agencies with contracts for custom media monitoring between 2002 and 2024. See also Sullivan (2012) (p. 20).

⁵In agency internal emails, there are many examples of other newsletters, Google news alerts, other automated alert systems, and emailed links to news coverage (see the supplementary online appendix).

are circulated widely and are consistently produced across a wide set of agencies and time periods. This consistency and ubiquity allows for comparison of government news collection across time and agencies.

The market for custom news reports is dominated by four companies: Bulletin Intelligence/Cision,⁶ Barbaricum, TechMIS, and Rendon. Bulletin Intelligence’s early employees were former members of the Reagan White House who had been previously tasked with producing Reagan’s news summaries. Based on their websites and other government contracts, Barbaricum, TechMIS, and Rendon are veteran-owned military contractors. While Bulletin dominated the market in the 2000s, it began losing contracts to Barbaricum, TechMIS, and Rendon in the mid-2010s. Today, all four companies hold lucrative contracts for agency news briefings.

According to the contracts, news briefings are generally targeted at agency leadership and communications staff. However, the email list often extends beyond these two audiences. The exact list of email recipients depends on the agency, but based on internal emails and the contracts, briefings are often sent to thousands of employees.⁷ In addition to staff who directly receive the full agency news briefing, some individual departments or offices forward a smaller set of relevant clips to their staff. Internal emails also reveal that employees forward the news clips as a way of starting policy-relevant conversations.⁸

Agency news briefings are the product of a multi-step process and tailored to the pri-

⁶Bulletin Intelligence was acquired by Cision, Inc in 2017 (Bulletin Intelligence, 2025).

⁷In a few cases, agencies have published estimated circulations. In 2023, DHS reported that approximately 5,000 employees receive the daily news briefing, and in 2014, the Nuclear Regulatory Commission (NRC) reported that all of its 3,000-4,000 employees receive the news briefings (Department of Homeland Security, 2023; Nuclear Regulatory Commission, 2014, p. 8). In 2017, one of the major contractors, TechMIS, reported that it served over 50,000 government employees (Mains, 2017, p. 5). See the supplementary online appendix for a list of all individuals confirmed to have received DHS, DOI, VA, and USCIS news briefings. In 2017, the Department of Interior (DOI) briefings were sent to the personal and professional emails of Secretary, Ryan Zinke, as well as to other top leadership, including his Chief of Staff and Press Secretary. Among other roles, numerous other recipients held positions related to communications, legislative affairs, intergovernmental affairs, and the budget office.

⁸For example, in an email chain from May 2017, DOI employees discuss how to respond to a local news story about coyote hunting (Foley et al., 2017). In another example from the VA, an employee suggests that an article in the news briefing be sent to the Commissioners prior to an upcoming meeting (Leinenkugel, 2018).

orities and goals of each agency. First, the contractor and agency decide on a procedure for identifying potentially relevant articles. Usually, this involves identifying a set of topics or keywords to monitor and selecting news sources.⁹ Next, the contractor applies human judgement and an expert understanding of the agency to sort articles into the appropriate section of the briefing, remove irrelevant or redundant information, and produce a short 1-3 sentence summary of each article.¹⁰ Each article citation is accompanied by basic metadata about the article, including a link to the full text or video, the authors, and the publication date. In summary, the composition of the briefing will depend on a series of decision by the agencies and their contractors: (i) which news sources to monitor, (ii) which keywords capture all potentially relevant articles, (iii) how to define and prioritize article relevance, and (iv) how to proceed when articles provide redundant information.

2.2. Why do agencies collect news?

While there is a rich literature on the importance of information and specialization in US bureaucracies (e.g. Gailmard & Patty, 2012; Workman, 2015), we know surprisingly little about how bureaucrats collect information. Given the rich information content of news, it should not be surprising that bureaucrats invest in news collection. Like many political elites, bureaucrats face critical strategic decisions where success or failure depends on their expectations about other political actors. News contains a wealth of information about the activities and positions of these actors (Cook, 1998). Many agencies also rely on news to monitor the effectiveness of their own communication efforts as well as to gather other policy-relevant information (Baumgartner & Jones, 2015; Bustos, 2021; D. Carpenter, 2014; D. P. Carpenter & Krause, 2012). As a result, they have fundamentally different incentives

⁹Typically, these topics align with the headings or section titles in the briefing document. While consulted, agencies may not pre-specify every source monitored by their contractor. In a 2017 document, TechMIS claims to monitor over 50,500 traditional print and broadcast news sources as well as 400,000 social media accounts or blogs (Mains, 2017, p. 5).

¹⁰Typically, the articles are then aggregated by ‘story.’ For each story, only one to four article summaries are provided. For stories picked up by many news organizations, additional articles are cited at the bottom of the story but not separately summarized.

for consuming news media, relative to the general public.

For bureaucrats, the value of news is not necessarily tied to perceptions of trustworthiness or factual accuracy. Whereas members of the public tend to seek out news they regard as credible and that aligns with their partisan or ideological leanings (e.g. Guess, 2021; Iyengar & Hahn, 2009; Mangold et al., 2024), bureaucrats generally need to monitor their political adversaries and correct false narratives, leading them to value news from low-quality or untrustworthy sources. Because the content of news and the politicians featured in news varies by partisan slant (Kim et al., 2022), we would expect bureaucrats and the agencies they represent to seek out news from a diverse and comprehensive set of sources.

While an agency’s optimal strategy for news collection will depend on a multitude of factors, their motives for collecting news will generally disincentive biased selection of ideologically-aligned news sources. These motives can be sorted into three general categories: (1) monitoring the strategic environment, (2) evaluating agency communications, and (3) gathering policy feedback.

First, agencies use news to monitor their strategic environment. While information may be available through other channels, media coverage is often the most straightforward and efficient means of finding out what is going on in politics (Cook, 1998). It is not a coincidence that news collection has been a critical part of open source intelligence collection for over a century (Van Puyvelde & Rienzi, 2023).¹¹ In addition to monitoring external actors, agency leaders use news to monitor their own agencies and reduce agency loss through “reality testing” (Burke & Greenstein, 1989; Karpowitz, 2009).¹² All media monitoring contracts require that briefings contain coverage of the agency, and most specify that the briefings will be used to keep their staff and leadership broadly informed about developments outside of their agencies.¹³ Often, briefings have dedicated sections for national news and/or news

¹¹Importantly, intelligence collection is not limited to newspapers in countries with free press. Even in the most highly censored, repressive regime, news coverage contains information relevant to predicting the government’s future actions.

¹²See also the literature on censorship and authoritarian regimes (Distelhorst, 2013; Lorentzen, 2014).

¹³For example, in its media monitoring contract, the Nuclear Regulatory Commission (NRC) states that its “officials and staff must start each day fully informed about local, regional, national and international

about other institutions like Congress, the White House, or the Supreme Court.¹⁴

Second, media contains information critical to evaluating an agency’s communications or public relations efforts. An agency’s reputation is a vital strategic asset that can be used to manage internal and external threats (Bustos, 2021; D. P. Carpenter & Krause, 2012). Almost every contract connects news monitoring to communications or public relations, and many specify that they are interested in monitoring “public interest” in the agency or a “larger public conversation.”¹⁵ In addition to protecting their reputations, agencies with strong communications capacities are better positioned to advance policy goals and core missions.¹⁶ This is evident in contracts from both public-facing agencies like the Department of Veterans Affairs (VA)¹⁷ and those that primarily interact with other institutions, such as the Drug Enforcement Agency (DEA).¹⁸

Third, news can play a role in policy feedback and provide other information relevant to policymaking. While information about their strategic environment and communications effectiveness can have policy implications, the news media plays other, more direct roles in policymaking. In their contracts, the Consumer Product Safety Commission¹⁹ and De-

news that is of interest to, or could impact, the NRC (Nuclear Regulatory Commission, 2014, p. 5).

¹⁴For example, the Department of Interior requires a ‘national news’ section in their briefing “suitable to the needs of Department Officials who must be kept aware of important developments affecting the federal government broadly so they can interact with peers in the administration and congress” (Department of the Interior, 2021, p. 2). Similarly, the Department of Justice requires a section on ‘Administration, Congress, and Supreme Court’ (Justice Management Division of the Department of Justice, 2012, 2018, 2022).

¹⁵For examples, see Environmental Protection Agency (2016); Small Business Administration (2022); Drug Enforcement Agency (2019); Nuclear Regulatory Commission (2014). For bureaucrats with limited direct feedback mechanisms, media coverage can serve as an important indicator of public sentiment. Surveys of bureaucrats have found that career civil servants are attentive to media portrayals of their agency’s work (Karlsen et al., 2020).

¹⁶See also Cook (1998), who argues that news can help agencies achieve policy goals (p. 148-149). Emergency communications is another case where communications effectiveness has been linked to policy outcomes (Bonnievie et al., 2021; Environmental Protection Agency, 2016; Miller & Goidel, 2009; Prue et al., 2003; Small Business Administration, 2022).

¹⁷For the VA, communication is critical to informing veterans and their families about available benefits and programs (Department of Veterans Affairs, 2013).

¹⁸The DEA promotes its mission by raising public awareness about U.S. drug laws and their consequences (Drug Enforcement Agency, 2019, pp. 4–5).

¹⁹The CPSC’s contract explains that “Emerging hazards identification, remedial strategy analysis, and regulatory development activities are built upon timely receipt, review, and analysis of news clips covering incidents occurring throughout the country” and that due to past news briefings, “serious product-related accidents reported by the news media have been brought to the attention of the Commission” (Consumer Product Safety Commission, 2020, pp. 4–14).

partment of Labor²⁰ describe using the media to monitor for ‘fire alarms’ (McCubbins & Schwartz, 1984).²¹ More generally, media can influence policymaking by shaping how the government detects and defines policy problems (Baumgartner & Jones, 2015).

All of these motives will generally push agencies to search widely for relevant news, collecting articles from a wide range of sources and perspectives.²² While an individual bureaucrat may disproportionately value a particular type of information, agency news briefings are designed to satisfy multiple audiences and purposes within the agency. The weight given to each potential motive may alter an agency’s optimal collection strategy, but it is difficult to imagine a case where a strong preference for co-partisan sources would satisfy all of the different constituencies within an agency.

While the agency as whole might benefit from a broad approach to news selection, it is possible for the briefings to be influenced by the interests of individuals within the agency. The contracts and internal emails suggest that the final composition of the briefings is a result of an incremental process where some individuals and groups have greater input. Contractors learn what to include in the news summaries by talking with agency staff and getting continuous feedback from various individuals at the agency.²³ Through this process, agency staff have the opportunity to influence the supply of news. Research on the mass public shows that individuals with higher political knowledge tend to prefer news sources aligned with their partisan leanings (Guess, 2021), raising the possibility that similar preferences

²⁰The DOL contract says, “news clips serve as an alert to emerging issues, leads for potential DOL investigations, and information that can be shared internally about ongoing programs or activities...[clips] point to problem areas that DOL agencies may need to address” (Department of Labor, 2020, p. 5).

²¹Scholars of authoritarian regimes have similarly recognized the value of media as a feedback mechanism, noting that censorship can be costly because it deprives governments of information (Distelhorst, 2013; King et al., 2013; Lorentzen, 2014).

²²For example, Agencies that prioritize learning about public opinion may prioritize collecting media from a diverse selection of widely-consumed sources, focusing on those that either reflect public opinion or have the most potential to shape public opinion. Alternatively, as predicted by Cook (1998), agencies that are highly dependent on other actors may seek out coverage of those actors, prioritizing outlets with specialized coverage of politics. Agencies with staff throughout the country may prioritize news from areas where their staff are located. In practice, agencies have multiple motives, and many of these motives produce observationally-equivalent outcomes. Thus, the final composition of the briefings cannot be used to identify the specific motive(s) of an agency.

²³See Joshua (2018).

among agency staff could shape the briefings’ content, even unintentionally. Alternatively, agency leaders may take steps to intentionally alter what information circulates internally.

Beyond individual preferences, the widespread circulation of briefings can also incentivize agency leadership to restrict briefing content under certain conditions. Two incidents during the first Trump administration suggest that other considerations can dominate the needs of some constituencies within an agency. In the first case, Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) leadership prioritized controlling the flow of information within the agency over maximizing the value of the news briefing to the EPA as a whole. In 2017, EPA leadership first pressured and then fired Bulletin Intelligence during a dispute about negative coverage of EPA leadership in the daily news briefing.²⁴ In the second case, the Department of Justice (DOJ) fired its contractor after employees complained to reporters about “a blog post from a white nationalist website [VDare] that used an anti-Semitic slur” (Barrett, 2019). While some parts of the agency might benefit from following a white nationalist news source,²⁵ the value was not large enough to outweigh the costs imposed on other employees and risk of additional negative news coverage (see also Aleaziz et al., 2019). While the motives were different, agencies narrowed the scope of their news briefings to control what stories circulated in both cases.

In summary, news collection within agencies is the product of multiple motives and goals. The final product will depend on the supply of relevant news and key decisions during the news selection process. As a whole, agencies should tend to actively seek out news from all partisan or ideological perspectives. However, when we consider the agencies as collections of individuals with their own biases and incentives, there are scenarios where individual biases or motives could affect news selection.

²⁴In emails, staffers complained about sending negative stories about their leader “everyone” (Choma & Leber, 2016; Leber et al., 2017), claimed that the stories were “junk” or “fake” news (Benton, 2017; Ericksen, 2017a), and argued that Bulletin couldn’t provide real-time alerts (Ericksen, 2017b).

²⁵Benkler et al. (2018) document that popular far-right sources like Breitbart pick up stories from VDare and circulate them to a wider audience (p. 124). Monitoring VDare would alert the DOJ to potentially damaging or inflammatory stories before they are picked up by other parts of the conservative media ecosystem.

3. Methods

Previous attempts to study elite news consumption relied on interviews and surveys (Kingdon, 1992; Sevenans et al., 2016; Sevenans, 2017a, 2017b). However, surveys and interviews may underestimate the role of news (Kingdon, 1992, pp. 59–60). Elite recollection of media consumption may be inadequate when they regularly review large volumes of information from a wide variety of sources. In such contexts, self-reports may fail to capture the scope and nature of news exposure. While internal government records have limitations, they offer a more detailed and verifiable foundation for studying elite communication.

To examine the balance of partisan news in agency news briefings, I first categorize the sources cited in agency news briefings. To assess whether the ideological biases of agency staff affect the selection of news, I compare news collection across liberal and conservative agencies and across Democratic and Republican presidential administrations. I also compare the agency news briefings to the news supply.

3.1. Daily News Briefs

For this paper, I collected custom news briefings produced for US executive agencies by private contractors.²⁶ To identify contractors, I used USAspending, which is the US government’s official database of federal spending information. I searched USAspending for ‘media monitoring’ contracts, focusing on contracts for ‘custom media monitoring reports.’²⁷ After identifying contractors, I searched publicly-available databases and submitted FOIAs for briefings produced by the contractors. I selected four sets of briefings where I had more than 30 copies of briefings from multiple presidential administrations. Collectively, these briefings were produced by three different third-party contractors under four presidential

²⁶To consistently identify daily news reports and reduce false negatives, FOIA requests and database search queries need to be specific. Reports produced by third parties were relatively easy to identify because third-party contractors use consistent naming conventions across their reports and often include their company name in their reports.

²⁷In total, I identified relevant contracts for 26 federal agencies. On average, each contract is worth approximately \$200,000 per year. For a full list of the contracts, see the supplementary online appendix.

administrations.

Department of Homeland Security (DHS) and US Citizenship and Immigration Service (USCIS) – The Department of Homeland Security (DHS) is responsible for policy areas and agencies related to immigration, security, and terrorism (Department of Homeland Security, 2025). The US Citizenship and Immigration Service (USCIS) is a sub-agency of DHS tasked with administering the US naturalization and immigration system (US Citizenship and Immigration Service, 2025). Webpages for TechMIS-produced USCIS and DHS news briefings are indexed and can be found through a search engine like Google.²⁸ Although USCIS is a subagency of DHS, the briefings are separate. USCIS and DHS have separate contracts with TechMIS. In total, I collected all USCIS briefings from February 1, 2022 through November 5, 2025 ($n=922$) and all DHS briefings from January 2, 2024 through November 5, 2025 ($n=655$). In both briefings, the citations contained hyperlinks. I identified sources by extracting the URLs and hyperlink text. A small number of cited articles were excluded from the analysis because they did not have URLs or identifiable names.²⁹

Department of Veterans Affairs (VA) – The Department of Veterans Affairs (VA) provides healthcare and benefits for US military veterans and their families (Veterans Affairs, 2025). Barbaricum-produced VA daily news briefings from June 3, 2020 through February 25, 2021 are available through the VA History Office’s Covid-19 archive ($n = 233$).³⁰ Like the DHS and USCIS briefings, I extracted hyperlinked URLs to identify cited articles.³¹

Department of the Interior (DOI) – The US Department of Interior (DOI) is responsible for numerous policy areas relating to national parks, wildlife, Native Americans, energy, and US territories (Interior, 2025). Unlike the other agencies, the DOI sample is not complete. To identify DOI briefings, I searched an online archive where journalists

²⁸Example link to DHS briefing: [https://dhs.techmis.com/epub/2024/Oct/3753706/3/todaysbrief/#page/epubdhs/DHS%20Morning%20Briefing%20\(10-3-24\).html](https://dhs.techmis.com/epub/2024/Oct/3753706/3/todaysbrief/#page/epubdhs/DHS%20Morning%20Briefing%20(10-3-24).html).

²⁹For more information, see appendix A.2.

³⁰The archive contains all VA briefings from June 3, 2020 through January 2021. Some of the February 2021 briefings are missing from the archive.

³¹For more information, see appendix A.2.

and interest groups post FOIA-produced documents. In total, I discovered 213 copies of DOI daily news briefings produced by Bulletin Intelligence between February 19, 2015 and November 13, 2018 ($n = 213$). Because the DOI briefing sample depends on journalist and interest group FOIAs, I only have briefings that mention certain keywords. While this could introduce bias, it is unlikely that sampling bias explains the results.³²

Because the hyperlinks were stripped from the pdfs, identifying the DOI sources required a different process.³³ To convert the DOI briefings into structured data, I used the Gemini 2.0 Flash large language model (LLM) to identify any news sources found in the briefings and extract the original text for each source, including any typos. I manually reviewed the resulting list of sources, removed misidentified sources, and added website domains. I then split the documents by heading and searched each section for text snippets.³⁴ To categorize each source and add source domains, I cleaned the text snippets, merged them with names of US news sources from ABYZ News Links, and filled in missing information based on my own review of the news source.³⁵

3.2. Categorizing Sources

To evaluate the balance of agency news diets, I categorized sources by partisan slant, which is the degree that a source’s reporting generally reflects a particular political affiliation or ideological leaning. I replicated the results in this paper using three different measures of partisan slant (see the appendix); however, I only report the Media Bias/Fact Check (MBFC)

³²If selection on particular FOIA topics affect a result, the result would vary over time because the FOIA topics change over time. To test for sampling bias, I verify that my results are consistent across the whole time period covered by the briefings (see appendix A.3 and A.4).

³³See appendix A.2 for a full description of this process.

³⁴Rather than search the full text, I only searched 10 word chunks preceding each forward parenthesis (“”). In the document text, news source names were almost always followed by descriptive information enclosed in parentheses.

³⁵ABYZ News Links (abyzlinks.com) has been used in other research, including Lutscher (2023) and Matter & Widmer (2021), and has been used by Media Cloud to identify news sources (Media Cloud Blog, 2020). ABYZ News Links categorizes news sources by location, geographic scope, media type, media focus, and language. For more details about the merging process, see appendix A.2.4.

scores in the main paper because they are the most complete.³⁶

When analyzing partisan bias, I excluded three types of sources: local general interest news sources (25.5%), government websites (0.2%), and sources with no identifiable URLs or names (0.1%).³⁷ Local general interest sources are defined by their geographic scope, prioritizing news and stories that directly impact the residents of the community they serve. These stories can include national politics, but they more often cover topics like local and state politics, local sports, and entertainment. News outlets that focus exclusively on local or state politics (e.g. the Oregon Capital Chronicle) are not considered general interest.³⁸ General interest local sources were dropped because the MBFC scores were less complete for local news sources, and there was less agreement between the MBFC and Allsides scores for local general interest sources.³⁹ After excluding government and general interest local news, 5.3% of the articles in the briefings could not be matched to MBFC scores.⁴⁰

The news briefings tend to contain more center or liberal-leaning news, although there is variation across agencies and briefings. The amount of right-leaning news varies considerably across the briefings. The VA and DOI briefings contain relatively little right-leaning news (8.8% and 18.2% respectively) while the DHS and USCIS briefings contain relatively more right-leaning news (29.7% and 34.6% respectively).

³⁶See appendix A.4. Two of the sources—Media Bias/Fact Check (MBFC) and Allsides—use human coders to assign partisan slant scores, and Guess (2021) estimates slant based on website audience. Allsides and Guess (2021) scores are missing for more articles, and the missingness is correlated with agency ideology.

³⁷Sources were categorized by first matching the sources to ABYZ News Links and manually filling in missing information. Where possible, sources were matched by URL host or domain. Where URLs were missing or not identifiable (e.g. link to video hosting service), I matched by source name. For more details about dropped news sources and articles, see A.5.2. Government websites were identified as those with .mil or .gov domains. Several additional government websites were identified during the hand-coding process. These include other military websites like “dvidshub.net” and “usni.org” as well as some local government websites like “countynewscenter.com,” “lincolncityhomepage.com,” and “genesee.ny.us.”

³⁸For more details about categorization of sources, see appendix A.2.5. See appendix A.3.3 for a detailed breakdown of the briefings according to source type.

³⁹See appendix A.4.1 and A.4.2.

⁴⁰Of these, most briefings are missing partisan scores for less than 6% of articles; however, the VA briefing is missing scores for 29.3% of articles. The VA briefing has more missing scores because it contains more news from smaller, specialized news outlets.

3.3. Agencies

By exploiting the structure of the DOI and DHS news briefings, I estimate news collection for 16 separate agencies.⁴¹ Both the DHS and DOI are large cabinet agencies that oversee many smaller agencies, bureaus, and offices. Their briefings are broken into sections, and some of these sections are dedicated to specific subagencies (see Table 1). Thus, the DOI and DHS briefings can be used to estimate the news collection for 15 different agencies. Estimates of DHS and DOI news collection use the whole briefing, including sections that do not correspond to a specific subagency (e.g. “top news”). Estimates for their subagencies use only the section of the briefing corresponding to the subagency. Because USCIS has its own dedicated section of the DHS news summary, the USCIS results are estimated twice. The first estimate is based on the separate USCIS news briefing. The second is based on the USCIS section of the DHS news briefing.⁴²

To test whether agency ideology shapes news collection, I used agency ideology scores from Richardson et al. (2018).⁴³ Their scores characterize the long-term policy views of government agencies and range from -2 to 2.⁴⁴ The sixteen agencies in my main analysis represent a wide range of ideology scores (-1.59 to 1.79).

⁴¹See Table 1 and appendix A.2.6. The VA and USCIS briefings do not have any headings that correspond to sub-agencies. Because the DOI headings change partway through 2017, a Bureau of Indian Affairs (BIA) section is only available for 2017-2018. Headings may be dropped from individual briefings when there is no relevant news coverage.

⁴²The USCIS results suggest that the composition of a subagency’s briefing is reasonably similar to its section of the parent agency’s briefing. This is consistent with agency emails, where subagency staff discuss their input into the briefings. For example, in 2018, an employee from a DOI subagency emailed two directors, writing that she regularly sent the contractor (Bulletin Intelligence) specific articles to be included in the next day’s news summary and invited them to also send “articles that are important to your mission and you think should be highlighted [in the main DOI briefing]” (Joshua, 2018).

⁴³Richardson et al’s (2018) scores were used because they are available for the most agencies. One other agency ideology measure is available for more than five agencies in my sample (Napolio et al., 2025), but its use of a large language model partially trained on news media raises concerns about reverse causality. Where possible, I have verified that my results replicate when using alternative measures of agency ideology (Chen & Johnson, 2015; Clinton & Lewis, 2008; Napolio et al., 2025).

⁴⁴Richardson et al. (2018) calculated these scores using a 2014 survey of political appointees and civil servants. Respondents were asked, “Some agencies have policy views due to law, practice, culture, or tradition that can be characterized across Democratic and Republican administrations as liberal or conservative. This can be an important feature of the environment of public management in these agencies (which is why we ask about it)...In your opinion, do the policy views of the following agencies tend to slant liberal, slant conservative, or neither consistently in both Democratic and Republican administrations?” (p. 304).

Table 1: Composition of briefing data. Sample sizes calculated after dropping local general interest sources and government websites.

Briefing	Agency	Name	Part of Briefing	Years	Total Arti- cles	Total Dates
DOI	DOI	Department of Interior	Whole Briefing	2015-2018	27,082	213
DOI	BLM	Bureau of Land Management	Section	2015-2018	525	167
DOI	FWS	Fish and Wildlife Service	Section	2015-2018	1,093	198
DOI	GS	US Geological Survey	Section	2015-2018	323	127
DOI	NPS	National Park Service	Section	2015-2018	1,505	207
DOI	BOR	Bureau of Reclamation	Section	2016-2018	93	56
DOI	BIA	Bureau of Indian Affairs	Section	2017-2018	232	101
VA	VA	Department of Veterans Affairs	Whole Briefing	2020-2021	2,386	230
USCIS	USCIS	US Citizenship and Immigration Service	Whole Briefing	2022-2025	26,773	922
DHS	DHS	Department of Homeland Security	Whole Briefing	2024-2025	61,446	655
DHS	CG	Coast Guard	Section	2024-2025	1,875	539
DHS	FEMA	Federal Emergency Management Agency	Section	2024-2025	5,243	634
DHS	SS	Secret Service	Section	2024-2025	1,980	511
DHS	TSA	Transportation Security Agency	Section	2024-2025	1,128	413
DHS	USCBP	Customs and Border Protection	Section	2024-2025	3,664	638
DHS	USCIS	US Citizenship and Immigration Service	Section	2024-2025	2,459	573
DHS	USICE	Immigration and Customs Enforcement	Section	2024-2025	6,414	602

3.4. News Supply (Media Cloud)

As previously described, the composition of the briefings is determined by the supply of news and the news selection process. To determine whether agencies prioritize some news sources over others, we need to account for differences in the supply of news. More precisely, we need to estimate the supply of news relevant to an agency. Figure 1(a) visualizes how contractors select articles for agency news briefings. In short, there are three primary steps: (1) collect all published articles, (2) identify a set of potentially relevant articles using keywords, and (3) use human employees to select articles for the news briefings.

While I could not identify all keywords used to identify potentially relevant articles, the agency name is almost certainly one of these keywords.⁴⁵ Thus, to estimate the supply of news, I queried Media Cloud, an open source collection of online news, for articles from US

⁴⁵During the contract solicitation process, a potential contractor asked, “Do you have a list of keywords to share?” and the DHS replied “We suggest including all component names and their jurisdiction as keywords to start” (Department of Homeland Security, 2018, p. 8). For more evidence, see the contract excerpts in the supplementary online appendix.

news sources that mention each agency name (Roberts et al., 2021).⁴⁶ Figure 1 visualizes how querying agency names is used to approximate the set of potentially relevant news articles.

I collected two sets of data from Media Cloud. First, I collected coverage for all 165 agencies categorized in Richardson et al. (2018) during 53 randomly sampled weeks from January 2015 through May 2025.⁴⁷ Second, I collected all of the media mentioning the agencies in the briefings during the periods covered by the briefings. For this second set of Media Cloud data, I then matched the results to the briefings.⁴⁸ Referring again to Figure 3b, this matching process allows me to define the set of articles in Region C by identifying which articles in the supply of relevant news (Region B) are also in the briefings (Region A).

As with any database of media scraped media content, the Media Cloud database may be missing some articles. In the appendix, I evaluate the quality and representativeness of the Media Cloud sample. I find that the quality of news collection can vary across time, which is why I do not use the Media Cloud data to evaluate news briefings across different presidential administrations. However, my analysis suggests that the Media Cloud sample is representative of variation across agencies. Even if data is missing for some time periods, we can still evaluate how news outlets allocate limited reporting resources during the periods where data is available.

⁴⁶For a full list of the keyword phrases used in this analysis, see appendix A.5. As a robustness check, I also replicated this analysis using another large opens source collection of news: the Global Database of Events, Language, and Tone (GDELT). See appendix A.6.

⁴⁷The weeks were selected using stratified random sampling and 6-month strata. An extra week was sampled from April 2025; removing it does not affect the results. *Note:* I am currently collecting Media Cloud data from another 40 weeks between 2015 and 2019. Pre-2020 data became available recently. Given the API quotas, it will take another few weeks to finish. As of Nov 17, 2025, the sample contains 53 weeks: 43 weeks from 2020-25 and 10 weeks from 2015-19. I intend to collect another 30 weeks from 2015-19 over the next 3 weeks.

⁴⁸I matched the data using three methods: (1) exact match by article URL, (2) match by website domain and the longest segment of the URL path, and (3) match based on the article publication date and domain. In the paper, I show the results using the third method because URLs are not available for the DOI briefings. See the appendix for additional details and quality checks.

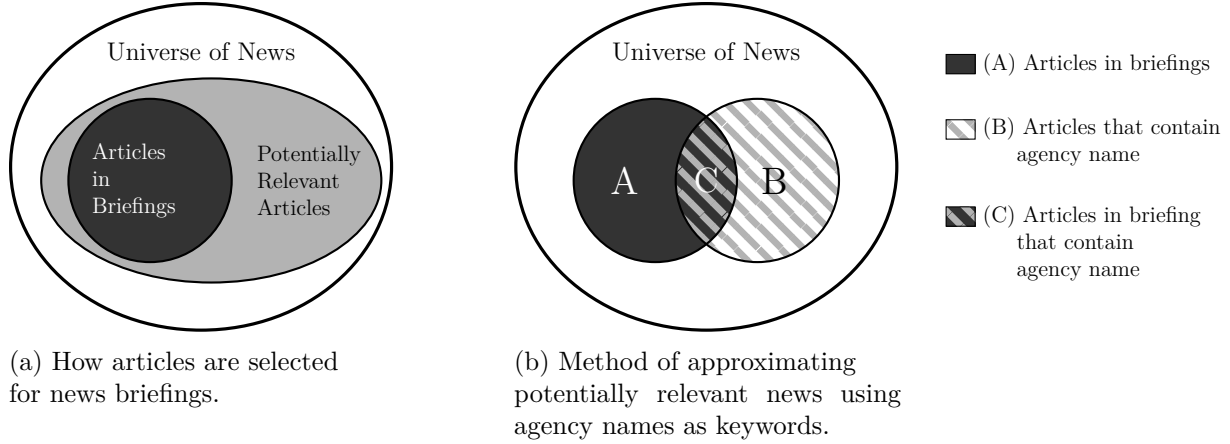


Figure 1: Diagram of agency news selection.

4. Results

Due to their varied motives and audiences, agencies should not systematically prefer news from co-partisan sources. However, individuals within an agency may impose their own preferences on the news selection process. To test agency behavior, I compare news collection across agencies by agency ideology. To test individual behavior, I examine news collection after presidential transitions

4.1. Variation across agencies

Is agency ideology associated with the partisan composition of news briefings?

If my hypothesis is wrong and agencies preferentially select ideologically-aligned news sources, we would expect briefings for conservative agencies to have more news from right-leaning news sources and less news from left-leaning news sources. Due to the structure of the US media market, this relationship should be particularly clear when comparing agency ideology to the amount of news from right-leaning news sources (Benkler et al., 2018; Guess, 2021). The scarcity of major center-right outlets makes it easier to differentiate center and right-leaning sources, creating less measurement error and more consistency across measures of partisan slant.

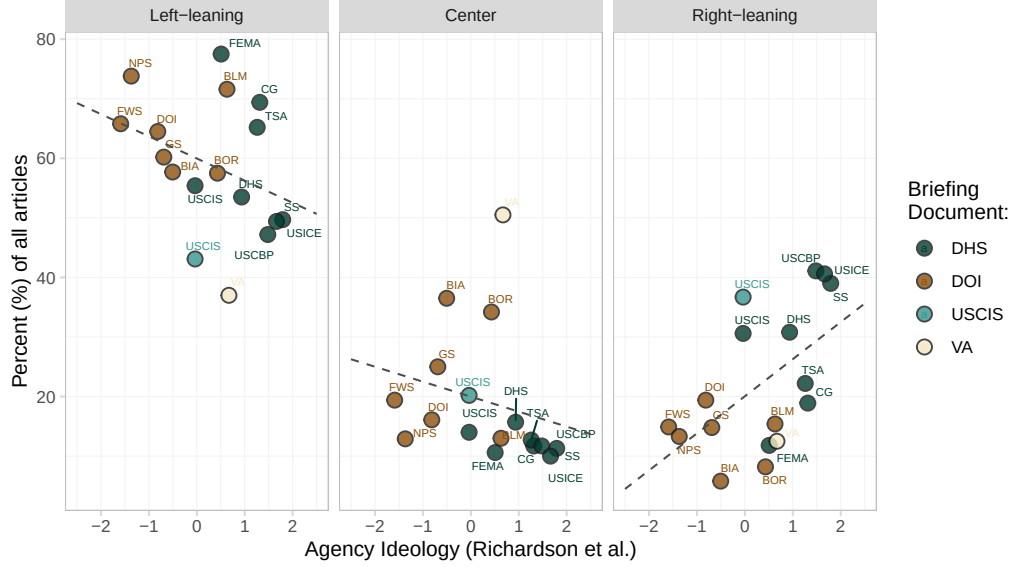


Figure 2: Association between agency ideology and the partisan-slant of sources in agency news briefings. The y-axis is the proportion of articles in a partisan-slant category (Center, Left-leaning, or Right-leaning). Partisan slant is determined by the source of an article.

To examine the relationship between the briefings and agency ideology, I calculate how often each briefing cites articles from a left-leaning, center, or right-leaning news sources.⁴⁹ Interestingly, the results in Figure 2 are consistent with preferential selection. Conservative agencies collect more news from right-leaning sources and less news from center and left-leaning news sources, relative to more liberal agencies. As expected, this pattern is most evident in the ‘Right-leaning’ subplot. The best fit line ($\beta = 0.062$) is substantively large: comparing the most liberal to the most conservative agency, we would expect an approximately 24.8 percentage point increase in right-leaning coverage.⁵⁰

While initially puzzling, the strong association in Figure 2 does prove preferential selection. The composition of the briefings is a function of the news supply as well as the selection process.

⁴⁹The proportion of articles with missing partisan slant scores is generally low and unrelated to agency ideology (see appendix A.6). In Figure 2, I drop articles from sources that could not be matched to partisan slant.

⁵⁰For regression tables and alternative regression specifications, see appendix A.4.11.

Is there an asymmetric supply of news?

Rather than reflect biased news selection, the association in Figure 2 could be produced by the supply of news if partisan news sources publish more articles relevant to agencies with similar ideological slants. To test this, I collect news mentioning different government agencies and calculate how much coverage is from right-leaning news sources.

While we do not know the exact set of outlets monitored by each vendor and keywords used to filter for relevant articles, we can make some reasonable assumptions. First, if an article is mentioned at least once in a briefing, that source is monitored by the vendor.⁵¹ Second, the keywords include the name of the agency.⁵² Given these assumptions, Media Cloud’s database of scraped news can be used to estimate the universe of relevant news available at a given time period (see Region B in Figure 1b).

Figure 3 plots the partisan composition of the news supply.⁵³ Each subplot contains different time periods and agencies. The first plot shows that composition of the briefings can be explained by an unbalanced supply of news. The second plot shows that this supply-side asymmetry extends beyond the agencies and time periods in the briefings sample.

For Figure 3(i), I limited the Media Cloud queries to agencies in the briefing dataset and the time periods covered by the briefings.⁵⁴ For each agency, I then calculate the proportion of articles from right-leaning sources. The regression line shows the relationship between agency ideology and the amount of coverage an agency receives from right-leaning news outlets. If the conservative sources preferentially cover conservative agencies or center/liberal

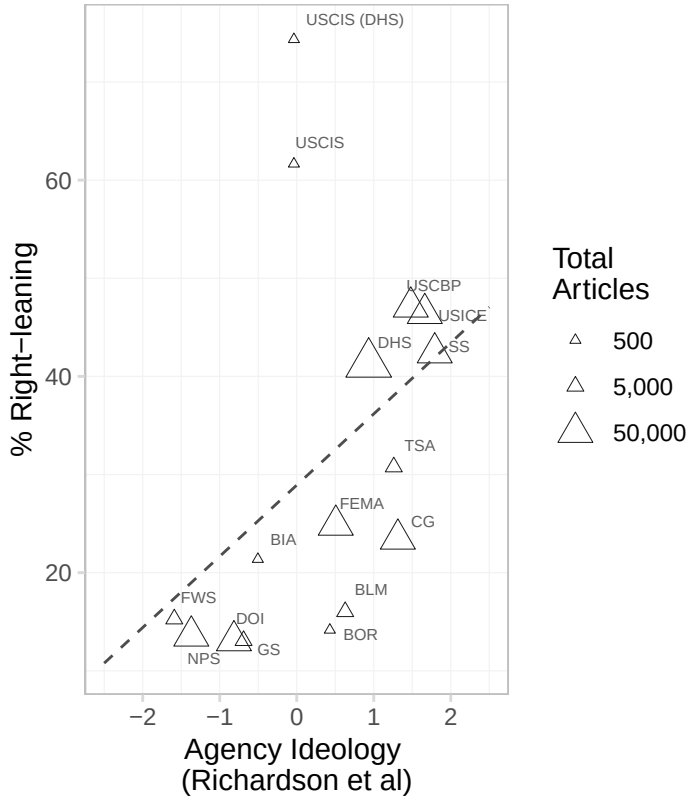
⁵¹I excluded articles from Media Cloud if (1) the source domain never appeared in a briefing, (2) it came from a general interest local source or government website, or (3) it came from an international source, which includes sources based outside the US or primarily covering other countries. Major wire services (AP, Reuters, UPI) were not counted as international sources. Because other countries have similarly named agencies, a large number of articles from international sources were not relevant to US agencies.

⁵²See appendix A.5 for the agency name queries.

⁵³For versions of Figure 3(i) and (ii) with the proportion of news from other partisan slant categories (center, left-leaning, and not categorized sources), see the appendix.

⁵⁴When I have a complete sample of briefings, I collected all news published between the first and last briefing in the sample. For the DOI and its subagencies, I subset the Media Cloud results to articles in the window directly before the date of a briefing in the sample. The results replicate when the window size varies (see the appendix).

(i) Briefing agencies and time periods



(ii) All agencies, 2015–2025

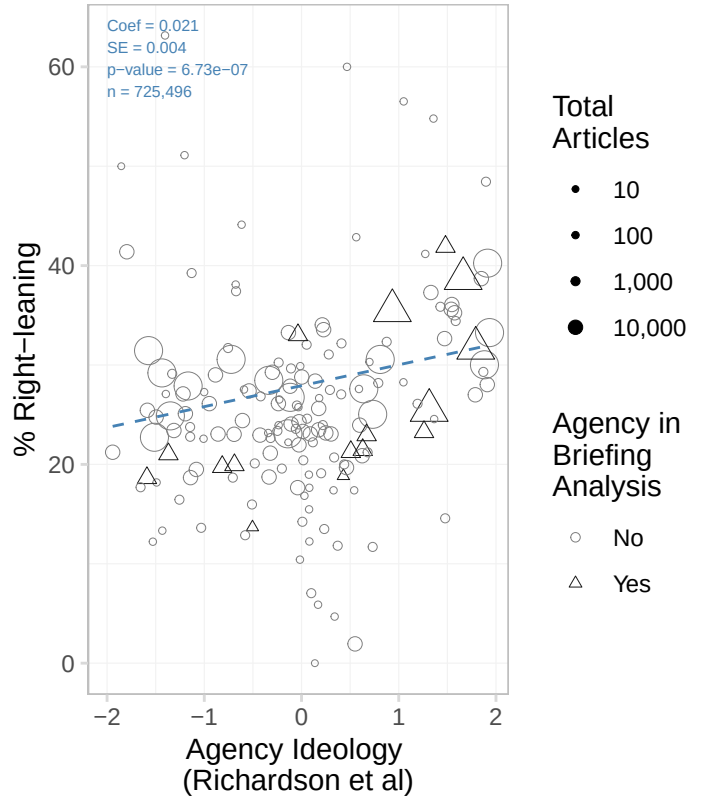


Figure 3: Supply of partisan news about government agencies. Supply of news collected using Media Cloud: (i) articles about briefing agencies during time periods covered by briefings; (ii) articles about agencies with ideology scores during 53 randomly sampled weeks from 2015–2025. Standard errors calculated using heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors and clustering by agency, news source, and article URL.

sources preferentially cover liberal agencies, we will see a positive coefficient. Consistent with this supply-side explanation, Figure 3(i) reveals a strong positive relationship between agency ideology and the production of news ($\beta = 0.073$). Specifically, partisan news sources are more likely to publish news about ideologically-aligned agencies. To better compare the supply-side disparity to the briefings, I recalculate the regression line from Figure 2 after dropping domains that are not collected by Media Cloud ($\beta = 0.076$). The effects are similar across measures: for a one-unit change in agency ideology, right-leaning outlets produce about 7.3 percentage points more coverage mentioning the agency by name and compose roughly 7.6 percentage points more of its news briefing.

In Figure 3(ii), I examine whether the asymmetries in Figures 2 and 3(i) are unique to

the time periods and agencies in the briefing sample.⁵⁵ Examining the relationship between the supply of news and agency ideology does not require agency briefings, so I extended the Media Cloud queries to include all 165 agencies with ideology scores from Richardson et al. (2018) and a longer time series. For Figure 3(ii), I randomly sampled 53 weeks from 2015-2025 and collected coverage mentioning each agency name. For each agency, I then calculate the proportion of articles from right-leaning sources.

Figure 3(ii) reveals that there is a durable asymmetry in the supply of news, one that affects agencies outside of the 16 in the briefing sample. To calculate the standard error of the regression line in Figure 3(ii), I clustered the standard errors by agency, news source, and article URL.⁵⁶ The plot shows a statistically-significant, positive relationship between an agency’s ideology and the amount coverage it receives from right-leaning news sources. Compared to the most liberal agencies, the most conservative agencies receive approximately 8 percentage points more news from right-leaning media sources ($\beta=0.021$, $se=0.004$, $p=6.73e-07$, $n=725,496$).⁵⁷

Is there evidence of preferential selection after controlling for the supply of news?

While the results in Figure 3 suggest that a supply asymmetry could explain the relationship in Figure 2, the analysis is not conclusive. To formally test whether there is any evidence of selection bias conditional on an article being published, I directly compared the briefings to potentially relevant articles published during the same period.⁵⁸

⁵⁵As an additional robustness test, I replicate these results using 17 randomly sampled weeks (2017-2023) from a second publicly available media database, GDELT (Global Database of Events, Language, and Tone). I also reproduce the plot using other media slant measures from Guess (2021) and Allsides. See appendix A.6. In the appendix, I also assess whether the supply disparity is driven by specific news outlets by examining whether the supply-side asymmetry exists for individual news outlets (see the appendix).

⁵⁶Each agency only has one ideology score, so the independent variable is assigned at the agency-level. Partisan slant is determined by the slant of the news source, so dependent variable is assigned at the source-level. Clustering by article URL addresses the non-independence of observations arising when a single article mentions multiple agencies. The Media Cloud query results are stacked such that an article can appear in the dataset multiple times, once for each agency name in the article. The final dataset contains 725,496 article-agency pairs, 541,337 unique URLs, 165 agencies, and 332 sources.

⁵⁷See appendix A.5 for alternate regression specifications.

⁵⁸Like the previous analysis, I drop articles from Media Cloud if (1) the source domain never appeared in a briefing, (2) it came from a general interest local source or government website, or (3) it came from an

Referring back to Figure 1b, I collect the set of articles mentioning an agency’s name (Region B) and determine which articles were included in the news briefings (Region C). I then determine whether the included articles (Region C) are more likely to be from right-leaning news sources, compared to the other potentially-relevant articles (Region B).

In Figure 4, I match the Media Cloud dataset to the briefing data using the article publication date and domain.⁵⁹ The resulting ‘matched sample’ contains all published articles that mention each agency name and an outcome variable that is 1 if the article is matched to the briefings and 0 otherwise. If an article with the same news source and publication date could be found in the relevant briefing or section of briefing, all articles from that news source were counted as included.⁶⁰ Because article URLs were available for about half of the agencies, I also matched by URL and used the results to validate the match quality.⁶¹

Before testing for preferential selection, I used the matched sample to check whether articles mentioning an agency’s name are representative of all articles in the news briefing. For all but one agency, these tests support my method; however, they raise concerns about about the representativeness of the USCIS results.⁶² First, I estimate how many articles in the briefings mention an agency’s name. In other words, I compare the included articles (Region C) in Figure 1b to all articles in the briefings (Region A). For most agencies, articles with agency names make up at least 10-40% of the briefing articles.⁶³ However, USCIS is mentioned in <1% of the articles in its briefing or section of the DHS briefing. Second, I

international source. The results are similar if all local, government, and international sources are included in the regression (see the appendix).

⁵⁹Publication date is available for all Media Cloud articles and for 98.5 of the articles in the DHS, DOI, and USCIS briefings. Due to the structure of the VA briefings, the publication date could not be determined. When matched by URL, the VA results are also null (see the appendix).

⁶⁰For example, when matching the Media Cloud results to the DHS briefing, I looked for a matching article anywhere in the briefing. For a subagency like FEMA, I only looked for a match in the FEMA section of the DHS briefing.

⁶¹See the appendix for error rate estimates. Although URL matches are only possible for approximately half of the briefing sample, they can be used to test the validity of other matching strategies. Based on this error rate analysis, one source had an abnormally large false positive rate (yahoo.com) and has been dropped from Figure 2. See the appendix for additional discussion.

⁶²See the appendix for more details and robustness checks.

⁶³See the appendix. Because some articles have multiple URLs, these numbers likely underestimate the number of briefing articles that mention an agency’s name.

check that the results in Figure 2 replicate when the briefing sample is limited to articles mentioning agencies by name (Region C). For all but one agency (USCIS), the results of this test suggest that the matched sample is representative. Due to these tests and the small size of the USCIS sample⁶⁴, the USCIS results should arguably be dropped. However, for transparency, I have included the USCIS results in Figure 4. Excluding the USCIS articles does not substantively affect the results.

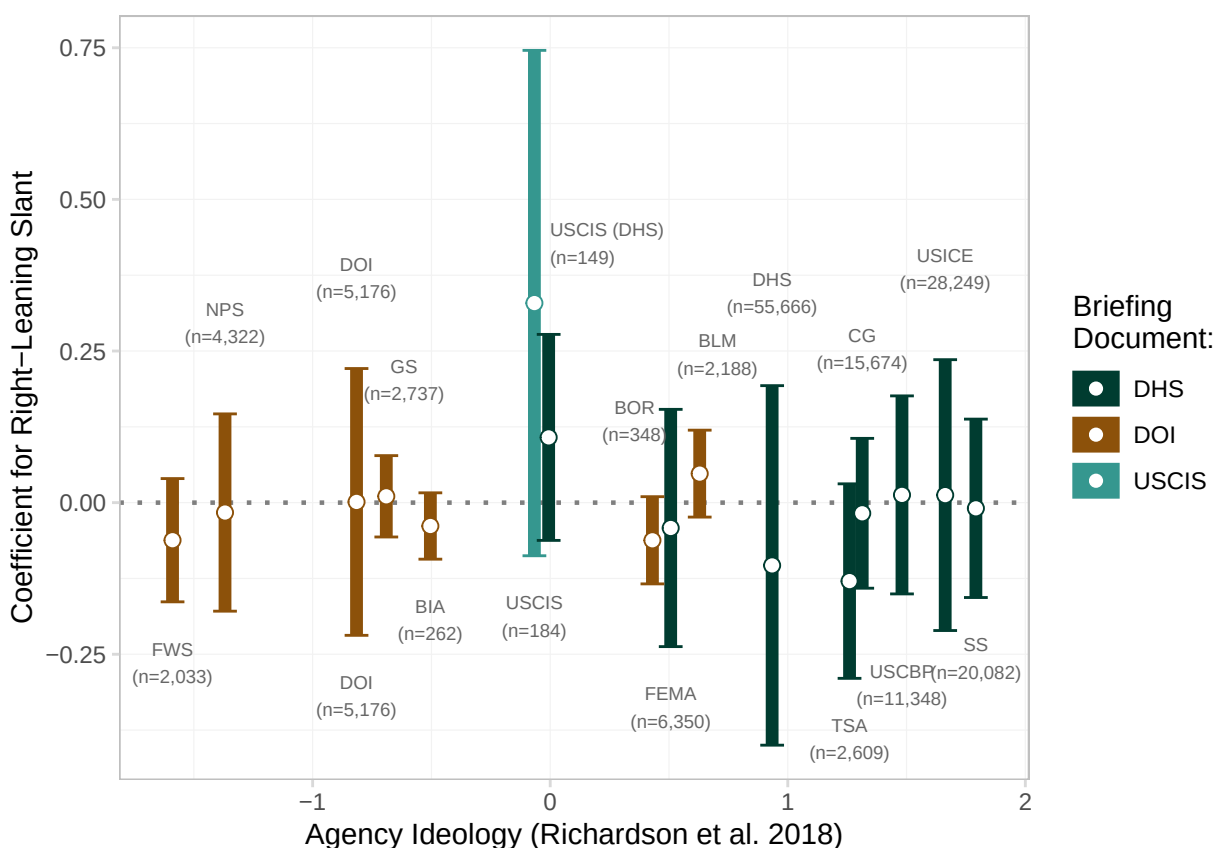


Figure 4: Estimated effect of right-leaning slant on the probability that an article is included in the news briefing. 95% confidence intervals. Models use OLS with robust standard errors clustered by news source and article URL. Outcome variable is binary indicator (1 if article included in news briefing, 0 otherwise). Independent variable is media slant; left-leaning sources are the reference category.

Formally, to test whether the slant of an outlet still affects its inclusion after accounting for supply, I use the following model: $Incl_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 S_i + \beta_2 I_i + \beta_3 (S_i \times I_i) + \epsilon$. For each

⁶⁴Over the whole USCIS briefing period from January 2022 through June 2025, Media Cloud identified 205 articles that mention the agency by name. Only 119 are from right-leaning sources, and most (61%) are from a single source (newsweek.com).

article i , $Incl_i$ is 1 if the article is included in the briefing, S_i is the slant of the news outlet, and I_i is the ideology of the agency mentioned in the article. If agencies are preferentially selecting articles from ideologically-aligned sources, the interaction between agency ideology and right-leaning slant would be positive. In contrast, the results suggest a weak, possibly negative relationship. Across various specifications, the interaction estimates are small, not significant, and usually negative (see the appendix).

I visualize this null result in Figure 4. Instead of an interaction, I run a separate regression for each agency, $Incl_i = \beta_0 + \beta_R \text{Right}_i + \beta_C \text{Center}_i + \epsilon$, and plot the coefficient for right-leaning news sources (β_R). A positive coefficient indicates that the agency is more likely to include articles from right-leaning sources, compared to left-leaning sources. A negative estimate indicates the opposite, and a value near zero suggests it is equally likely to include articles from left- or right-leaning sources.

In Figure 4, I arrange the coefficients by agency ideology. If agencies preferentially selected co-partisan news sources, we would expect the point estimates to be higher for more conservative agencies. Figure 4 shows that the estimates do not follow this pattern, providing no evidence of biased selection.

Collectively, the results yield three key findings. First, there is a strong association between an agency’s ideology and the extent to which it cites partisan news sources. Second, the supply asymmetry extends beyond the specific agencies and time periods included in the briefings data. Third, conditional on news publication, there is no evidence that liberal or conservative agencies prefer news from ideologically-aligned sources.

4.2. Variation across administrations

While the motives of an agency and its various components disincentivizes preferential selection, individuals within an agency could impose their own preferences on the news selection process, particularly in the highly-partisan climate of current US politics. To test whether the preferences of agency staff shape news selection, I examine the partisan composition

of the briefings across presidential transitions. Political appointees have input into contracting decisions and help administer the contracts, and presidential transitions affect the composition of agencies and their leadership (Bolton et al., 2021; Spenkuch et al., 2023).

Evidence of changes across presidential administrations is mixed. The proportion of conservative coverage in the DOI briefings remains relatively stable from 2015 through 2018, including during the transition from Obama to Trump in 2017.⁶⁵ However, the DHS briefings underwent a dramatic change shortly after Trump took office in January 2025.

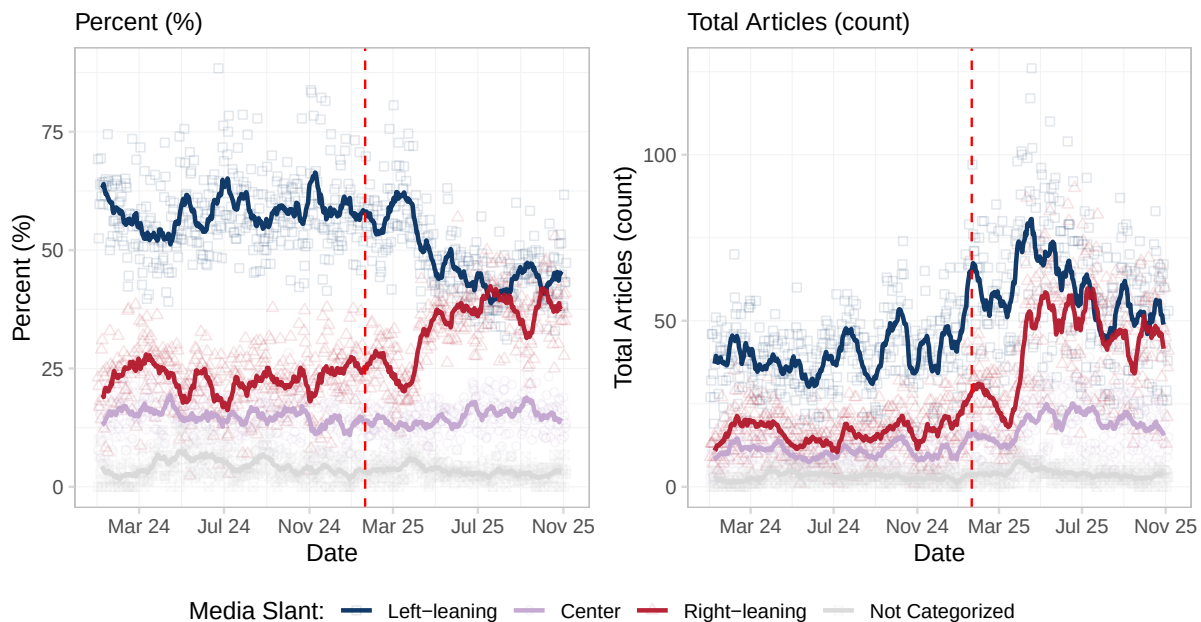


Figure 5: Over-time partisan composition of the DHS news briefings. Dotted line at Trump’s 2025 inauguration. Lines are 2-week rolling averages.

Beginning in late March 2025, DHS briefings began to incorporate much more right-leaning coverage (see Figure 5), a lasting change in composition that cannot be attributed solely to supply-side factors. Before March 2025, the DHS news briefings did not cite sources like Breitbart, Newsmax, the Blaze, the Daily Wire, the Daily Caller, the Daily Signal, and the Federalist. Since April, all of these sources have been featured prominently.⁶⁶ Because these sources were never included in DHS briefings prior to March 2025, their addition cannot

⁶⁵See appendix A.4. The VA briefings also show little change, but the available briefings stop about a month after Biden’s inauguration.

⁶⁶See the appendix. For example, Breitbart became the 5th most cited source.

be attributed to changes in the news supply.⁶⁷ Additionally, the placement of conservative news also suggests preferential treatment. Conservative articles are now concentrated at the beginning of the news briefing, which is where the most important stories are generally placed (Sullivan, 2012).

Interestingly, despite being housed under DHS, the balance of partisan coverage in the USCIS briefings follows a different pattern. Overall, the long-term composition of the USCIS briefings changed less dramatically. However, upon closer examination, an anomalously large number of new right-leaning sources were also added around April and May 2025.⁶⁸ In both the USCIS and DHS briefings, there is a clear deviation from the normal process of adding sources. In April and May, there is a spike in the number of new sources and their ideological extremity. Notably, there is no equivalent spike in DOI or VA briefings.

In summary, leadership may affect the partisan content of the news summaries under some circumstances. Those circumstances were not present at DOI in 2017 but are present at DHS in 2025. Additional conservative news sources have also been appearing in the USCIS briefings, but unlike at DHS, these changes have not affected the overall composition of the USCIS briefings.

5. Discussion

This paper examines how federal agencies collect information from the news and whether their efforts reflect systematic partisan biases. I first consider agencies as unitary actors, assessing patterns across the organization as a whole, and then examine individual incentives by looking at presidential transitions. The results suggest that agencies as a whole do not systematically prefer ideologically aligned news outlets. However, they raise important

⁶⁷In order for supply to explain the number of newly added conservative sources, sources like Breitbart would need to have produced zero relevant news before March 2025. Using Media Cloud and/or the source websites, I verified that each of the 31 right-leaning sources added after April existed before 2025.

⁶⁸See the appendix. Starting in April, the USCIS briefings increasingly cite sources like Breitbart, Newsmax, the Blaze, the Daily Wire, the Federalist, One America News Network (OAN), and the Daily Signal. Interestingly, while some of these sources were occasionally cited during the Biden administration, they were rare and not cited after 2023.

questions about the consequences of an asymmetric news supply and how agencies should approach news collection. While less conclusive, the recent changes to the DHS briefing suggest that agency leadership can influence news selection, particularly in highly politicized environments.

Importantly, this paper reveals that asymmetries in the supply of news are reflected in agency news exposure. To fully understand the consequences of asymmetric coverage, additional research will be needed on its origins and implications. Nevertheless, prior research on government decisionmaking and partisan media suggest that the asymmetric supply observed in Figures 2 and 3 has important political and policy consequences. Examining this research also suggests directions for future research and provides insight into the normative implications of an asymmetric information supply.

Generally, information about the existence of policy problems and demand for policy change has been shown to affect policy decisions and elite strategy. Various studies have linked media to government activity. The only previous study of government news summaries (Karpowitz, 2009) used Richard Nixon’s handwritten notes to prove that information in the White House news briefings affected Nixon’s communications efforts, policy-making activity, personnel management, and emotional state. Studies have also linked news exposure to important judgement about public opinion (Broockman & Skovron, 2018; Furnas & LaPira, 2024), the existence of policy problems (Baumgartner & Jones, 2015), the importance of policy problems (Van Aelst & Walgrave, 2016; Walgrave & Van Aelst, 2006), the best solutions to policy problems (Jablonski & Seim, 2024), and the activities of other political actors (Cook, 1998). Beyond studies of media, information has been shown to affect elite decision making and responsiveness (Jablonski & Seim, 2024; Liaqat, 2019; Seim et al., 2020). Collectively, this research suggests that differences in news content can affect policymaking when they affect judgement about public opinion or the existence, severity, and solutions to policy problems.

Turning to prior research on partisan media bias, existing research has established that

left- and right-leaning sources produce different information. A large body of existing research has established that the partisan slant of a source shapes the information content of news by affecting story selection and presentation (Broockman & Kalla, 2025; Groeling, 2013; Grossman et al., 2022; Hosseinmardi et al., 2025; Larcinese et al., 2011; Mullainathan & Shleifer, 2005; Puglisi, 2011; Puglisi & Snyder Jr, 2011; Shultziner & Stukalin, 2021). This evidence is further bolstered by the results of this paper. The asymmetric supply of news shown in Figure 3 illustrates how right-leaning news sources produce more coverage of conservative agencies and less coverage of liberal agencies.

Future research should investigate the causes and consequences of the partisan asymmetry found in Figure 3. Compared to the dangers of asymmetric supply, more attention has been paid to the dangers of preferential news selection (e.g. Broockman & Kalla, 2025). Nevertheless, an asymmetric supply of news also raises concerns, particularly in the context of elite news consumption and given the size of the disparity. Some liberal agencies collect almost no coverage from conservative sources. If bureaucrats believe that the briefing collection process is unbiased, they may be less likely to recognize supply-driven limitations to their information environment. Being aware of bias has been shown to mitigate the effects of bias (Lee, 2017). An incomplete information supply could increase the chances that the agency makes a strategic error, but it could also affect agency behavior in less visible ways, like forcing an agency to expend more resources on other types of information collection efforts. Unless they explicitly seek out conservative voices from other sources, liberal agencies will have less information about the thoughts and opinions of conservatives elsewhere in government and in the wider public.

Interestingly, outside of a few sectors like emergency communication, there has been limited prior research on how political elites should optimize media monitoring. The lack of clear guidance may explain why very few media monitoring contracts contain specific provisions for ensuring the balance of agency news briefings.⁶⁹ When combined with political

⁶⁹Only one contract contains quotas or other provisions for ensuring source diversity, and its quotas apply to the geographic diversity of local news coverage (Consumer Product Safety Commission, 2020). None of

sensitivities around news diversity, agency staff or the monitoring service itself may choose not to adopt more complex optimization strategies and instead favor basic heuristics like selecting news equally or in proportion to the news supply. Alternatively, it is possible that agency staff have not actively considered the optimal diversity of partisan sources; in which case, it is more likely that their feedback will be shaped by their own biases (Beattie & Snider, 2019; Kahan, 2016). Especially in the age of large language models and other technological advancements, future research should consider how to design government media monitoring strategies that efficiently capture the full breath of information in news.

As expected, the complex motives behind agency news consumption disincentive agencies from preferentially seeking out co-partisan news; however, under some circumstances, the partisan preferences of powerful individuals within an agency could shape the selection process. Figure 5 reveals that the composition of DHS news briefings changed dramatically after Donald Trump returned to office. Under Kristi Noem’s leadership, coverage from far-right news sources has increased in volume and prominence. While Figure 5 shows a dramatic and persistent change, the briefings alone cannot conclusively identify the cause of this change. There are several possible explanations, some of which are consistent with the agency’s overall preferences while others require the priorities of agency leadership dominate other motives for news collection.

First, the new administration could make different judgements about the value of news to the agency as a whole. Not all sources are created equally. In order to create a quickly digestible and representative picture of the news, agencies might choose to prioritize information based on factors like source popularity, influence, or accuracy. Agencies may also choose to exclude low-value information when the cost of including it is too high. Agencies may choose to remove particularly offensive or false information from a document circulated widely within an agency. Given the DOJ’s decision to fire TechMIS over an antisemitic blog (Barrett, 2019), contractors themselves may adjust content to avoid controversy or termi-

the contracts require that contractors monitor an ideologically-diverse set of sources.

nation. Individual judgements of value or cost are influenced by personal attributes like partisan affiliation (Bhuiyan et al., 2020; Ladd & Podkul, 2018) as well as the broader political environment. For example, it may be particularly valuable to have sources monitored by the president, even if they contain offensive or false information.

Alternatively, political leaders may impose their own preferences on the briefings, at the expense of other constituencies within the agency. Most obviously, agency leadership may see these briefings as an opportunity to advance a political agenda by shaping the information environment of other leadership and staff. The EPA’s dispute with Bulletin Intelligence during the first Trump administration suggests that leaders might also seek to insulate themselves from negative coverage (Benton, 2017; Choma & Leber, 2016; Dravis et al.; Ericksen, 2017a; Leber et al., 2017).

While there are legitimate reasons for restricting or expanding collection of extreme or low-quality news, the changes at DHS raise concerns. Concentrating news from highly-partisan news outlets known for disseminating inaccurate information in the ‘top news’ section of the briefings suggests that current DHS leadership is not simply seeking more diverse sources of information. At a critical time in US immigration policy, the prominence of relatively extreme conservative news sources may both reflect and reinforce the administration’s priorities.

Recent changes to news briefings reflect a broader pattern of politicizing information and manipulating access to media coverage. For decades, the government’s extensive efforts to collect, curate, and distribute news drew little outside notice. That changed when these once-routine practices came under heightened political scrutiny. In the early months of his second administration, President Donald J. Trump and his team devoted significant attention to government news consumption and payments for news services, going so far as to cancel widely used services from Politico and other news service providers.⁷⁰ This paper highlights

⁷⁰In addition to targeting Politico, Trump’s administration has also explored cancelling other center- and left-leaning news subscriptions (Basu & Caputo, 2025; Guardian Staff, 2025) and taken steps to limit access to news at the Social Security agency (Sheffey, 2025).

a consequence of these actions. These decisions were not merely symbolic; they actively obstructed and politicized the supply of information flowing to government agencies.

Together, the findings of this paper show that while agencies generally do not select ideologically congenial news, they operate within an information environment shaped by substantial partisan asymmetries in the supply of coverage. Under certain circumstances, choices by agency leadership can also alter the balance of information available to government staff. These results underscore the need for continued research on information collection within bureaucracies and how informational disparities affect their decisionmaking.

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